

Kazakhstan



The last Soviet republic to declare its independence, Kazakhstan has mineral and agricultural wealth.

1500s Kipchaks and other Turkic, Mongol, and Iranian groups break away from the Mongol Golden Horde and migrate to the territory now known as Kazakhstan, forming three nomadic states: the Senior Zhouz (Horde) in the southeast, the Middle Zhouz in the northern and central areas, and the Junior Zhouz in the northwest.

1846 The Senior Zhouz joins the Russian Empire. By 1865 the whole of present-day Kazakhstan is in Russian hands.

1889 Russian eastward expansion leads to a law on designated areas for state-aided settlement, including regions of present-day Kazakhstan.

1916 Rebellion against Russian rule is brutally suppressed.

1917 Russian Revolution inspires civil war in Kazakhstan between Bolsheviks, anti-Bolsheviks, and Kazakh nationalists. Russian settlement intensifies after 1917 as Kazakhstan is subjected to industrial and agricultural development. Nationalists set up an autonomous republic.

1920 Bolsheviks take control: Kirghiz Autonomous Soviet Socialist Republic is set up within Russian Soviet Federative Socialist Republic, later the USSR.

1925 The Kirghiz ASSR is renamed the Kazakh ASSR as the Soviet Central Asian territories are reorganized into three autonomous regions and two republics.

1930s Stalin's collectivization program leads to an increase in Russian settlement and the deaths of an estimated one million Kazakhs.

1936 Kazakhstan becomes a full union republic of the USSR as Kazakh SSR.

1941–45 Large-scale deportations to Kazakhstan of Germans, Jews, Crimean Tatars, Chechens, Ingush, and others felt to be a threat or to be disloyal to the USSR during World War II.

1950s Nuclear test site set up at Semipalatinsk; 500 nuclear explosions follow before testing ends in 1991.

1954–60 Soviet policy to plow the "Virgin Lands" for grain is most vigorously followed in Kazakhstan, despite the environmental consequences.

1986 Riots in Almaty, the then capital, after an ethnic Russian, Gennadi Kolbin, is appointed head of the Kazakhstan Communist Party (CPK) to replace an ethnic Kazakh, Dinmukhamed Konayev.

1989 Kolbin is replaced by Nursultan Nazarbayev, an ethnic Kazakh.

DECISIVE MOMENT

FIRST MAN IN SPACE, 1961

On April 12, 1961, Yuri Gagarin, pictured right in his spacesuit, became the first man in space. His flight, a single orbit of the Earth lasting 1 hour, 48 minutes, began on top of a 4.5 ton *Vostok* ("East") rocket launched from the Soviet space center at Baikonur in Kazakhstan.

The Baikonur cosmodrome is the world's oldest: construction began in 1955, and several historic flights were launched from there, including the very first artificial satellite, *Sputnik I*, in 1957. After Kazakhstan became independent in 1991, Russia negotiated an agreement to continue to use the center until 2050.



1990 CPK wins elections to supreme soviet by an overwhelming majority: Nazarbayev is appointed first president of Kazakhstan as the country declares sovereignty within the USSR.

1991 Kazakhstan votes to preserve the USSR as a union of sovereign states. As the USSR breaks up, it is the last of the 15 constituent republics to declare its independence and join the Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS). The CPK restructures itself as the Socialist Party of Kazakhstan (SPK).

1992 Opposition demonstrations against the dominance of reformed communists in the supreme soviet, now the supreme Kenges. Nationalist groups form Azat, the Republican Party. Kazakhstan is admitted to the United Nations.

1993 A new constitution is adopted and a new currency, the tenge, is introduced.

1994 Legislative elections are annulled after widespread voting irregularities.

1995 Kazakhstan, along with Belarus and Ukraine, gets rid of the former Soviet nuclear arsenal.

1995 Adoption of a new constitution broadening presidential powers and allowing the president to dissolve parliament and rule by decree.

1997 Capital moved from the southern city of Almaty north to Akmola (renamed Astana in 1998), partly to control the local Russian population in the region.

1998 Legislature approves constitutional amendments, including the holding of an early presidential election.

1999 Nazarbayev is reelected president for a further seven-year term in elections widely believed to be fraudulent.

2000 Legislation grants Nazarbayev with lifelong powers and privileges.

2003 Sale of former collectivized farmland is legalized as part of a program of economic liberalization and privatization.

2005 Nazarbayev is reelected for a

further seven-year term with more than 90 percent of the vote. Opposition leader Zamanbek Nurkadilov is murdered.

2007 The Kazakh parliament votes to allow president Nazarbayev an unlimited number of terms. His party wins all seats in the lower house in general elections.

2007 The Chinese and Kazakh presidents unveil the Kazakh section of a natural gas pipeline from China to Central Asia.

« 138–39 Nomads of the Steppes
« 184–85 The Silk Road

Uzbekistan



A territory fought over by many ancient empires and today the most populous Central Asian republic.

500s BCE Cyrus the Great, founder of the Persian Empire, conquers Central Asia.

327 BCE Alexander the Great conquers the states of Sogdiana and Bactria.

500s CE The Turks control Central Asia but are driven out by the Arabs in the 7th and 8th centuries, returning in the 10th century.

1500s The Shaybani Uzbeks rule an unstable region, from Bukhara and Samarkand.

1700s–1800s Uzbekistan ruled by Muslim khanates of Bukhara, Khokand, and Khiva.

1865 Expanding Russian Empire captures Uzbek city of Tashkent.

1876 Expansionist Russia completes the annexation of the khanates of Bukhara, Khiva, and Khokand.

1916 An armed uprising against Russian domination in Samarkand is crushed.

1917 The Russian Revolution leads to demands for an independent Bukhara. Soviet power established in Tashkent.

1921 Turkestan Autonomous Soviet Socialist Republic (ASSR), incorporating present-day Uzbekistan, is proclaimed.

1923–41 A new written language replaces the old Turkic language. Initially it is written in Arabic, but later it is changed to the Roman alphabet and finally to Cyrillic.

1924 Basmachi rebels, who resisted Soviet rule, are crushed. The Uzbek SSR is founded; until 1929, it includes the Tajik ASSR.

1925 Anti-Islam campaign bans religious schools and closes mosques.

1936 Karakalpak ASSR (formerly part of the Russian Soviet Federative Socialist Republic) incorporated into Uzbek SSR.

1937 Uzbek communist leadership is purged by Stalin.

1941–45 World War II gives rise to an industrial boom.

1959 Sharaf Rashidov becomes the First Secretary of the Communist Party of Uzbekistan (CPUz). He retains the position until 1983.



Cities of the Silk Road

The spectacular Shirdar Madrasa at Samarkand is one of the great Islamic schools of the world. Uzbekistan lies on the ancient Silk Road connecting China with Central Asia and the Mediterranean. Merchants created cities such as Samarkand along the route.